

HELICOPTERS IN VIETNAM

THE START OF FULL-SCALE US military involvement in Vietnam occurred at a time when a major increase in the number and variety of American military helicopters was taking place. The Chinook was already established as a transport workhorse, and the Sikorsky Skycrane had recently arrived to give a new heavy-lift capacity, while the first attack helicopter, the Bell Cobra, was undergoing flight tests. Going into the war, there was still scepticism in the US Army about the ability of rotary-wing craft to operate effectively in combat – they were widely seen as too vulnerable to enemy fire. But this soon evaporated as experience proved that helicopters could survive a lot of punishment, as well as dish it out themselves, if well-armed. The core of the helicopter fleet remained the all-purpose “Huey,” but increasing specialization was visible, for example, by the deployment of the Cayuse as an effective observation platform.

COBRA GUNSHIP

Cobra gunships (AH-1T shown) first showed their effectiveness as close support aircraft in the Vietnam War. See pages 300–1.



Bell UH-1 Iroquois (“Huey”)

Following the success of the helicopter in casualty evacuation in the Korean War, Bell designed this turbine-powered machine. Officially named Iroquois, it became universally known as the “Huey,” after its original designation, HU-1. On any one day during the Vietnam war, there might be 2,000 Huey sorties.



ENGINE 1,100hp Lycoming T53-L-11 turboshaft
ROTOR SPAN 44ft (13.4m) **LENGTH** 41ft 7in (12.7m)
TOP SPEED 138mph (222kph) **CREW** 2
PASSENGERS Three stretcher cases or up to seven seated

Boeing-Vertol CH-47A Chinook



The first Chinook was an enlarged version of the Vertol 107, first flying in 1961 as the Vertol 114. The initial production variant was the CH-47A which entered service in 1961 and soon became the “Huey’s” indispensable heavy-lift partner in Vietnam. By 1999, over 800 Chinooks had been built in numerous variants.

ENGINE 2 x 2,200shp Lycoming T55-1 turboshaft
ROTOR SPAN 59ft 1in (18m) **LENGTH** 51ft (15.5m)
TOP SPEED 168mph (270kph) **CREW** 2–3
PASSENGERS 44 troops

Hughes OH-6A Cayuse

In the early 1960s, Hughes was one of 12 companies competing for the US Army’s Light Observation Helicopter (LOH) competition. Nicknamed the “Flying Egg,” Model 369 was declared the winner in May 1965. In Vietnam, the Cayuse performed a variety of duties, including artillery spotting, escort, and reconnaissance. Part of its success derived from its advanced structural design, which balanced strength and rigidity with a low weight and streamlined fuselage.



ENGINE 317shp Allison T63-A turboshaft
ROTOR SPAN 26ft 4in (8m) **LENGTH** 23ft 2in (7.1m)
TOP SPEED 152mph (244kph) **CREW** 2
PASSENGERS 4

Sikorsky CH-53D Sea Stallion



First used in Vietnam in 1967, the CH-53 evolved out of the amphibious Sikorsky S-65, borrowing the Skycrane’s rotor system to give the US Marines a much-needed heavy assault helicopter and heavy-lift capability. The USAF also modified the type into the HH-53, their principal rescue helicopter, aka the “Super Jolly.”

ENGINE 2 x 3,925shp General Electric T64-GE-413 turboshaft
ROTOR SPAN 72ft 3in (22m) **LENGTH** 67ft 2in (20.5m)
TOP SPEED 196mph (315kph) **CREW** 3
PASSENGERS 55 troops

Sikorsky CH-54A Tarhe

The Sikorsky S-64A which flew in May 1962, was the first Skycrane. Successful field trials in Vietnam, under the military designation of YCH-54A Tarhe (an American-Indian word meaning “crane”), led to a large order and by 1965, the ungainly Skycrane was fully operational. It could transport damaged aircraft, artillery, and armored vehicles, while the cargo pod could be a field hospital, barracks, or a command post.

ENGINE 2 x 4,500shp Pratt & Whitney T73-P-1 turboshaft
ROTOR SPAN 72ft (22m) **LENGTH** 70ft 3in (21.4m)
TOP SPEED 126mph (203kph) **CREW** 3–4
PASSENGERS 87 troops or 20,000lb (9,070kg) load



Sikorsky H-34 Choctaw

The H-34 Choctaw, which entered US army service in 1962, was a derivative of the US Navy’s 1954 HSS-1 submarine hunter/killer. In 1962, the Choctaw was deployed to Vietnam, where it was used for staff transport and airborne search. However, it was the US Marines’ who became the primary user of the type with their UH-34 Seahorse variant, because the Army had concerns over vulnerability to ground fire. The US Army’s last Choctaws were retired in the early 1970s.



ENGINE 1,525shp Wright R-1820 radial
ROTOR SPAN 56ft (17.1m) **LENGTH** 46ft 9in (14.3m)
TOP SPEED 122mph (196kph) **CREW** 2–3
PASSENGERS 18 troops